

together on your financial problems. I'll be honest with you. About half of the couples the pastor sends to me don't ever come back after the first meeting. They are looking for either a guaranteed miracle or some kind of quick fix. But if you didn't get into debt in three months, you won't get out of debt in three months. And as far as miracles go, I have seen God move in miraculous ways, but the more common approach is that He allows those who violate His principles to work their way out. Somehow the lessons seem to stick a lot better that way."

"We're not looking for a miracle or a quick fix," Ben said. "I know I created this mess by my own ignorance and childishness. I'm willing to do whatever is necessary to solve this once and for all."

"What about you, Naomi?" Mr. Stanford asked.

"I'm committed to the Lord, my husband, and whatever else it takes—in that order," Naomi said confidently. "I have already closed my account and put the surplus in our joint account."

"Good for you. I believe Ben is going to be worthy of your trust, and I know God will honor your faith. Now let's get down to business."

"First, we would like to ask a couple of questions," Ben said.

"Go ahead."

"As you may have guessed, we haven't been attending a church regularly for the past year or so. But we made a commitment to join Pastor Rhimer's church last week. Naomi feels very strongly that we should begin to tithe again. I want to too, but I can't figure out where the money would come from, even with the two new debts paid. Can we tithe even if it means we can't meet the obligations of the Chapter 13?"

"I commend your commitment to join a good church and to tithe the Lord's portion, but when you signed the court decree, you pledged yourself to the plan you submitted. You can't legally break your commitment and remain under the plan.